

Spyware shouldn't be confused with viruses or worms, as a spyware package is not intended to replicate itself.

4.2 How Do They Attack?

Adware, spyware, and for that matter, any malware, can attack in a variety of ways.

4.2.1 Adware Attacks

As mentioned earlier, adware is usually bundled with a commercial software. It can install itself on your computer either with your permission or without your knowledge when you install the software package. Milder forms of adware are also present in the form of pop-up (and the increasingly common, pop-under) banners that pop up when you visit certain sites. These ads, sometimes referred to as “Java traps,” open up in several mini-windows—each time a window is closed by the user, code that spawns another window is activated.

Programmers sometimes add adware to their software packages in order to recover some of the cost of developing the package. If the package is freeware (see box *Some Terms Explained*), then the adware is used to make up for the entire cost of development. Shareware packages also sometimes carry adware that is activated once the trial period is over.

Adware can have several negative effects on your computer. It generally slows it down since it gobbles up some of your system's RAM. It also, to a large extent, slows down your Internet connection, as a lot of bandwidth can be used to download ad content.

Adware is generally licensed content, and therefore usually (though not always) requires the user's permission before being installed on the user's computer. It collects information about how one is using one's computer and the content transmitted